

I tried to sign before I'd read the text, but Mr. Epstein made sure I went back and informed myself of all the unpleasant details. The whole filling-out process took 10 minutes.

Then it was time to put in the money. Lind-Waldock requires a \$5,000 deposit to open an account, and I didn't have it. Mr. Epstein checked with the lawyers, who said they'd make an exception, being that I was writing a book, and would settle for \$2,000. I offered a personal check. Mr. Epstein again consulted with the higher-ups who said the check would have to clear before I could "initiate a position." This might take three days, which a motivated investor could never tolerate. I called my hometown Centrust S&L long-distance and asked them to wire the funds, but they refused. A clerk said he didn't recognize my voice and had no proof it was really me. "For your own protection," he explained, and I hadn't even told him what I was doing with the money.

Mr. Epstein and I explored this predicament together and had the same brainstorm at once, trading futures on a credit card. The credit-card idea seemed logical enough, but the higher-ups said they weren't set up for it. It did, however, lead us to the actual solution, which, if you're ever short on cash in Chicago and anxious to trade a future, I'd recommend. Traveler's checks.

I found the American Express travel office on Michigan Avenue, a few blocks from the Mercantile Exchange. I presented my credit card to a very pleasant Mrs. Riley and received \$2,000 of investment capital in less time than it would have taken to buy a plane ticket. "Have a nice trip," she volunteered as I was signing the backs of the checks. I returned to Lind-Waldock, endorsed the checks over to them, and got my account approved. Mr. Epstein gave me my personal trading code, plus an 800 number to call anytime I wanted to put in an order, 24 hours a day.

The next problem was what futures to trade. On this matter, Mr. Epstein was helpful as usual—and so was Bill Murshel, the public relations man at the rival Chicago Board of Trade. From the two of them I gathered up all the brochures and booklets that anyone could carry, and then I holed up in my cut-rate hotel to study the material. Some titles I remember include: "Writing Puts, Straddles, and Combinations," "Call-Option Spreading," "The